



As a painter, you participate in an activity that humans have practiced for at least 15,000 years, since Paleolithic people at the end of the last Ice Age are known to have created images on cave walls in France and Spain (Figure 1.1). Prehistoric painted images also have been found on rock walls in Africa and Australia. Because of the fragility of

paint materials and the ravages of time, there is no way of determining where and when the practice of painting initially began. In fact, as a way of image-making, painting may have developed independently in multiple social settings, at dispersed places around the globe. What we do know is that over the past one hundred and fifty centuries, the art of painting in its multiple guises has been actively pursued by people in many diverse societies.

(such as photographs or sand) with paint. So we might say that a painting is whatever a painter makes. While the contemporary art world places great emphasis on just this aspect of our definition (to the degree that painters are often judged successful if they push the definition of painting beyond traditional notions), for our purposes this answer merely substitutes one unknown for another. If a painting is what a painter makes, then who is a painter? Unless we are careful, we soon find ourselves circling back into the endless loop of a tautology.

Answering the question, "What is a painting?", requires more careful thinking on our part. Perhaps we can slip free of what looks increasingly like a philosophical riddle by reframing our opening question as, "What is a painting made of?"

As we will explore in the chapters that follow, paintings consist of four interactive layers of meaning: physical materials, painting techniques, formal elements, and

WHAT IS A PAINTING?

What is a painting? The simple answer to this question is: a painting is any artwork which is painted. This definition, while having the advantage of being grounded in common sense, leaves the door open to such follow-up queries as, What is an artwork? Are all objects that are painted paintings? For example, is a painted fence or the painted wall of a house a "painting"?

As we shall see in later chapters, some painters make artworks that combine other materials and textures



1.1 Anonymous artist/s, Cave paintings of horses, Lascaux, France, c. 15,000–9,000 B.C.E.

cognitive (intellectual) meaning. Each is integral to the impact a painting makes upon a viewer.

What is a Painting Made of?

Physical Materials

A painting is an object, or, more precisely, it is the tangible painted image or design adhered to an object as well as the object itself. Like all objects, paintings are created out of physical materials. (Indeed, this statement remains true even with the so-called "paint" software programs designed for use with computer technology.)

The physical materials most paintings consist of include the paint itself and the surface upon which the paint is applied. The paint itself is composed of *pigments*, *medium*, and a *binder*. The surface to which paint is applied is called the *support*. We discuss these terms below. More extensive descriptions of various materials available for use by painters are provided in the next chapter.

Pigments

Pigments are the colored elements from which artists' paints and pastels are made. Pigments exist in a dry form as small, colored particles of fine powder. These particles of pigment are insoluble, but can be suspended in various oils, water, and other liquids. The result is the spreadable colored material known as paint. Pigments derive from a variety of sources, including plants, minerals, ores, and chemical compounds. They may be found naturally or made synthetically. Most likely you will not be working with pigments in dry form; instead, you will buy tubes of paint in which pigments are already combined with a liquid substance.

Medium and Binder

Definition #1: The term *medium* is used for the liquid within which pigment particles are suspended to form paint. The *binder* (or "vehicle") is the substance mixed into paint to make it adhere to a surface once it dries. Sometimes the medium and binder are the same substance. In oil paint, for example, the same drying oil serves as the medium and binder. In watercolor, by contrast, water is the medium while water soluble gum is the binder.

Types of paint are commonly named according to the type of medium. Oil paints are formed with a vegetable oil, most commonly linseed oil. In watercolors, the pigments are combined with water, which evaporates upon application, leaving the color as a dry residue on the surface of the paper or other support. Acrylic paints are made from an acrylic resin (a form of synthetic plastic) that is polymerized and dispersed in water.

Definition #2: In painting, the term *medium* also refers to the additional liquefied substances an artist can add to paint to alter its consistency. Although paint can be applied directly from the tube, paint used in this way is often thick and somewhat difficult to spread with a brush. Typically you will add extra liquid to thin the paint. The extra liquid may be more of the original medium; frequently, it is a mixture of several liquids. In addition to thinning paint, various recipes for mediums are designed to achieve certain special effects, such as increasing the relative transparency or gloss of the paint film. Susan Rothenberg's painting *Butterfly* (Figure 1.2), for example, combines acrylic paint and matte medium on canvas. (Matte medium is a polymer emulsion that dries to a nonglossy appearance.)

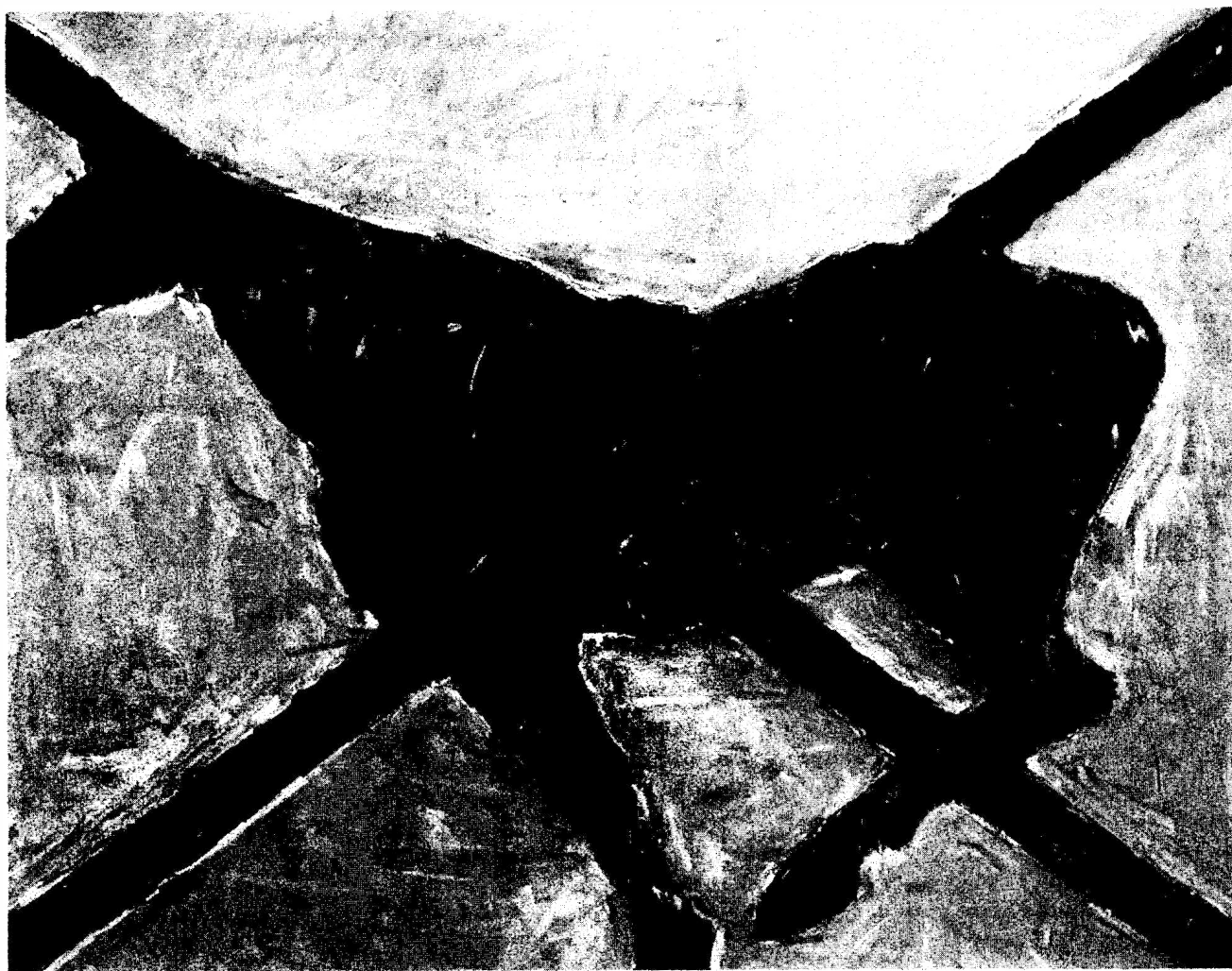
Further information about the ingredients and working properties of various mediums for oil painting and acrylic painting is provided in the next chapter. Throughout the book you will see examples and undertake various exercises exploring the use of specific painting mediums.

Definition #3: As if things weren't confusing enough, *medium* has a third meaning: it refers to the type of materials an artist uses to make an artwork. Defined this way, the medium might be bronze or wood (examples of materials a sculptor might use), or, for a painter, the medium might be oil on canvas, acrylic on paper, or some other combination of paint and the physical surface to which the paint is applied. To avoid uncertainty, throughout this text we will restrict our usage of medium to the first two definitions only: paint and the liquids you add to paint to alter its consistency.

Support

The *support* is the physical surface to which an artist applies paint. For the past four hundred years in the West, canvas fabric has served as the most common support for oil (and now acrylic) paintings. The canvas is usually stretched onto a wooden framework (called a *stretcher*) to make it taut enough to paint upon. Other materials have been favored as supports for other types of paint and in other periods and parts of the world. The support for a cave painting at Lascaux, for example, is the rock surface (Figure 1.1).

Paper is the preferred support for watercolor paintings as well as for paintings done in ink or *gouache* (an opaque version of watercolor mixed with extra gum arabic and an opaque substance, often chalk). There is a long tradition of painting on paper in many cultures of Asia and the Middle East.



1.2 Susan Rothenberg, *Butterfly*, 1976. Acrylic and matte medium on canvas, 69 $\frac{1}{2}$ " $\times$ 83". Gift of Perry R. and Nancy Lee Bass. Copyright © 1998 Board of Trustees, National Gallery of Art, Washington.

Wooden panels were a common support in Europe in the Middle Ages. Even today, many oil and tempera painters who wish to produce highly detailed images select wood or masonite panels in order to take advantage of their extremely smooth, hard surfaces. Painting on wood is also prevalent in folk art traditions of Europe and North America. Moreover, the painted decoration of wooden objects has been practiced in cultures across the globe, including many in Africa and the Pacific Islands, and among many Native American cultures.

An array of other materials have served as supports for paintings in the past and today, including animal hides, cardboard, papyrus, silk, plaster, metal sheets, glass, Plexiglas, and found objects. Moreover, the support for a painting is not always portable. As we said

at the start of this chapter, the oldest known paintings were created on rock walls. Throughout history there has been a vital practice of creating large-scale images on architectural walls, from the tomb paintings of ancient Egypt, to the fresco paintings of classical Greece and Rome, to the revival of fresco in the Italian Renaissance, to the twentieth-century murals made by painters in Mexico and the United States in the 1930s, to urban memorials painted on the sides of buildings today.

What is a Painting Made of? Techniques

Paint is applied to a support utilizing any one or a combination of techniques. For example, a painter may choose

to paint with opaque brushstrokes, intending each mark to cover that portion of the support to which it is applied. Alternatively, a painter may choose to apply paint in transparent or translucent layers, so that the final image is the result of a slow buildup of paint. Depending on their materials, various types of paint may require different techniques for their application (encaustic paint, for example, requires heating wax to a molten state). We discuss the primary characteristics and approaches of many basic painting techniques in Chapter 2.

The technique used by an artist contributes to a painting's visual appearance. For instance, applying paint in a technique utilizing smooth, blended brushstrokes may enhance an effect of photographic realism. Indeed, some artists and writers even utilize the term "technique" when naming the resulting visual style — "photorealistic technique," for example.

What is a Painting Made of? Form

By means of techniques, the physical materials of a painting are arranged into forms. While the term *form* is applied in several ways, in each case it refers to the specific and actual appearance of something.

First, the form is the overall physical structure of the artwork itself, a structure of specific dimensions and shape. For instance, the form of a painting might be a rectangle with outer dimensions of 48 inches in height by 36 inches in width by 3 inches in depth (from the front surface of the canvas to the back of the stretcher).

Second, a form is the specific representation of an object or figure within an artwork, such as the form of a male nude in a painting. (In a related usage, form is the appearance of an actual object in the real world, such as an object a painter observes when he paints from life.)

Third, the paint itself is given form as points, lines, shapes, colors, values, textures, and volumes. Together these are known as *formal elements* (they are also called *visual elements*).

Finally, the formal elements are grouped together in an overall arrangement called form (also called *composition*).

Within a composition, the formal elements interact with one another to create design and spatial relationships (including balance, stress, dimension, direction, movement, and scale). See, for example, how the various shapes in Rothenberg's painting (Figure 1.2) interact with one another within the overall composition. We analyze examples of these relationships in ensuing chapters.

While a painting's formal elements are customarily embodied in paint, painters have also experimented with

the attachment of nonpaint materials (such as photographs or words cut from newspapers) as well as with the alteration of the overall shape of the support itself. Later in the book, you will try creating multi-part, non-rectangular, and even nonpaint paintings.

Each of the formal elements can be discussed independently, and this is often useful for instructional purposes. But you must also learn how these same formal elements operate within the context of the entire composition. We see a painting as a visual phenomenon in which the whole is more than the sum of the parts. From an overall perspective, we observe the broad characteristics of form known as *style* that recur in the paintings of an artist, group of artists, or even an entire culture or period of art. The style of Rosa Bonheur's painting (Figure 1.3), for instance, is more *naturalistic* (more natural looking) than the style employed by Catherine McCarthy in *Riding Through Streams* (Figure 1.4). Rather than creating one continuous space within which to embed her subject, McCarthy superimposes various whole and fragmented treatments of her subject across the picture plane.

Visual experience is dynamic. We do not perceive a painting as an undifferentiated mass of physical material nor as a static mosaic of lines, shapes, colors, and textures. Formal elements coexist in the painting's composition; their interaction creates a field of active forces. Colors may appear to vibrate; a shape may pulse with energy as it appears to be in perfect balance with other shapes and a corner of the canvas.

What is a Painting Made of? Cognitive Meaning

From our discussion so far, we know that a painting is composed of physical materials that an artist has shaped into a specific form through the use of one or more techniques. But things don't stop here. A painting also contains *cognitive meaning* (sometimes referred to as cognitive content). The cognitive meaning of a work of art includes its intellectual, symbolic, emotional, thematic, and narrative connotations. Cognitive meaning is interrelated with the other three components we have discussed: cognitive meaning derives directly from the materials and forms of the painting and the techniques the artist has employed. Cognitive meaning also derives from outside knowledge (such as familiarity with religious symbols, patterns of social behavior, and knowledge of other paintings by the same artist) which the viewer and artist utilize in the process of interpreting a specific painting's meaning.

Focus On

PAINTINGS OF HORSES

Figures 1.1, 1.2, 1.3, and 1.4

To illustrate the complexity and subtlety of how paintings communicate and are interpreted, we observe that paintings sharing the same subject matter may otherwise communicate vastly different messages. For example, you may have noticed that the four paintings illustrated so far in this chapter feature images of horses. But is their content identical?

Bonheur (Figure 1.3) gives a virtuoso demonstration of how closely a painter can replicate the appearance of a real horse. Indeed, the artist based her style on direct observation of live animals and firsthand study of anatomy through visiting slaughterhouses. Rothenberg (Figure 1.2) tests how a painted image of a horse can hover at the edge of abstraction. While Rothenberg appears to be using the horse shape mainly as a means to explore formal “painterly” issues of balance and composition, Bon-

heur takes us outside the painting to a consideration of aspects of the relationship of humans to animals. The prominence given to the magnificent horses through lighting and dynamic poses compared to the insignificant humans at their side communicates Bonheur’s belief in the superiority of animals.

In her painting (Figure 1.4), McCarthy juxtaposes snippets of verbal text with images of horses. On closer inspection, we find the equine images change before our eyes—from ordinary animals to dreamlike beasts; some are even centaurs: half horse and half adolescent girl on the edge of sexual maturity. The total effect of the painting is a wonderfully engaging exploration of the process of growing up and a joyous celebration of giving free rein to one’s imagination. We undertake a more extended examination of the possibilities of narrative painting in Chapter 10.



1.3 **Rosa Bonheur**, *The Horse Fair*, 1853. Oil on canvas, 94 $\frac{1}{4}$ " $\times$ 16' 7 $\frac{1}{2}$ ". The Metropolitan Museum of Art, Gift of Cornelius Vanderbilt, 1887. (87.25)

(continued)

Finally, while we can only speculate as to what the Paleolithic artists who painted the horses on interior cave walls meant to communicate, to us the images stand in part as testimony to the persistent ef-

forts by humans in all times and places to make sense of their surrounding world (Figure 1.1). In sum, despite sharing equestrian subjects, each of these artworks evokes a varied response from viewers.



1.4 Catherine McCarthy,
Riding Through Stream, c. 1990s. Oil on
canvas, 38" × 24". Courtesy of the artist.

CONTENT

We use the term *content* to refer to the total meaning of a work of art. A change in any one of the four “active ingredients” necessarily alters the overall content of the painting. For each viewer, the content of a painting is the sum of how that viewer makes sense — makes meaning — out of the interaction of the materials, techniques, form, and cognitive meaning the painting is made out of.

Content is not identical with *subject matter*. Subject matter is whatever a painting depicts, that is, its imagery. Throughout history, in most cultures, the subject matter of paintings has usually been *representational* — imagery which a viewer can recognize and name, such as fruit, horses, trees, a person, a goddess, and so on. But subject matter may be *nonrepresentational* — imagery that does not refer to anything tangible that exists outside the painting. In the latter case, the subject matter might be a series of squares of various colors. Figure 1.2 combines representational subject matter — a horse — with nonrepresentational subject matter — an X shape.

Being able to identify the subject matter does not mean you know what a painting is about or all that it is about. The content of a painting is what we interpret as its overall meaning; this meaning derives from the subject matter as it is communicated through medium, form, and technique. As noted, the content is affected by additional cognitive information that is invested in the painting and influences the context within which it is understood, such as our knowledge of the artist’s biography or the social conditions prevailing at the time the painting was created.

Like other forms of communication (such as spoken and written language, music, mathematics, and even what is popularly known as “body language”), painting has a special vocabulary along with guidelines for making effective use of that vocabulary. Because the vocabulary of painting is visual, for both artist and viewer a painting is first and foremost a visual experience. While this point may seem obvious even to the raw beginner, its implications are all too frequently overlooked or ignored. The content of a painting is never fully translatable into words; there can be no complete verbal reenactment of a painting since a painting’s specificity of meaning and effect are borne, color by color and brushstroke by brushstroke, by its visual language.¹

That a painting employs visual means, however, in no way necessarily limits the purpose of a painting to a

description of what can be seen with the eyes. Indeed, paintings that ostensibly have similar subject matter may communicate vastly different meanings. One painter may intend to create a straightforward description of what fruit physically looks like; another may use fruit to symbolize other meanings, for example, depicting blemishes on pears to suggest the fragility of life. Paintings are conceived for many different reasons: to describe the physical world, tell a story, impart a moral lesson, express emotion, pay homage to a political leader, protest injustice, provoke social change, or simply provide a new look at the relationship between two colors. Many contemporary paintings are created, at least partially, for the purpose of challenging previous notions of what a painting is (i.e., what a painting is made of, to use our own terminology).

The fact that a painting employs visual means does not mean that we should judge its success strictly in terms of visual criteria. While we may be charmed by the subtle color scheme of one painting and the verisimilitude of another, our admiration sometimes stems primarily from the force of the artist’s expression of emotion or from the intellectual challenge of the artist’s ideas. Many of the most intriguing paintings seem to operate simultaneously on visual, emotional, and intellectual levels.

We perceive a painting via our senses and simultaneously become engaged in the process of making sense of the painting. This is the process of interpretation. We may interpret a painting in a highly conscious and carefully structured manner, or we may apply a more intuitive process.

We each come to a painting with a considerable range of knowledge about how to look at and interpret visual sensations, including whatever past learning we have had regarding pictorial images in general and paintings in particular. As viewers, we may bring to a painting an understanding of the social conditions under which the work was created, and knowledge of other paintings by the same artist. These color to some degree how we conceive meaning.

While some theorists believe that the content of a painting stems entirely from the painting itself (mostly produced by the painter’s intentions), and others believe that the content is “authored” by the viewer (whose interpretation, in turn, is controlled by the indoctrinating influence of society), we believe that content is established by a combination of forces operating in both directions. This forms the basis of our approach to learning to paint with power and purpose: you learn to tap into that

which bears the strongest personal meaning for you; and you learn to express meaning by using the visual language of painting in ways that communicate effectively to a wide range of viewers.

PAINTING AS A LANGUAGE

The title of this book is *Painting as a Language: Material, Technique, Form, Content*. It might have been simpler (and intellectually less risky) to title the book, *Learning to Paint: Material, Technique, Form, Content*. But we elected to use *Painting as a Language* . . . because we wanted to emphasize, as a primary feature of our pedagogical point of view, that paintings have content and that the practice of painting is a form of communicative behavior. The title emphasizes that painting is a mode of producing and embodying symbolic meaning, and that this mode of producing and embodying meaning (the practice of painting) is like a language, at least metaphorically. Painting is a language with its own visual lexicon (forms, materials, and techniques that interact to embody meaning), and it incorporates conventional knowledge of "grammar" (how earlier artists arranged and related painting's visual qualities into meaningful constructs). Our approach asserts that painting is a language that possesses an inexhaustible capacity for constructing meaningfulness, including the constant potential for each painter to evolve new "dialects" involving his or her own idiosyncratic approach to form, materials, techniques, and cognitive meaning.

Furthermore, the title initiates a confrontation (a fruitful intellectual exchange, we trust) with those readers who may come to the study of painting with any number of received notions. By foregrounding the idea of painting as a language, we purposely challenge any notions that paintings are primarily made for decorative or strictly formal purposes (art for art's sake), or that the one and only proper goal for all paintings is to portray accurately the visual appearance of a specific real-life subject, or that the one and only proper goal for all paintings is to serve as a means for the individual artist's expression of emotion. While all these, and more, have undeniably been valued goals for painting at specific moments in the cultural history of various societies, we have aimed to write an introductory text that serves the wider needs of developing artists at the dawn of the twenty-first century.²

Modes of Pictorial Representation

Throughout history, the vast majority of paintings have incorporated images that function as representations of something else. All such images serve as signs for the represented subject matter. But the relationship of the image as a sign to what it signifies, what it represents, is often overlooked. We readily understand that although a square with two small triangles on top can serve as a sign for the head of a cat, the image itself is not really a cat. On the other hand, we may overlook or lose sight of the fact that a highly detailed, seemingly naturalistic representation of a cat is a sign as well, and differs significantly from any actual cat (the image is flat, the fur is only paint, and so forth). Bonheur's horses (Figure 1.3) are no more alive than McCarthy's (Figure 1.4).

In progressing through the chapters of this text and looking at the various examples of paintings that are illustrated, it is expectable that many readers will presume that some paintings are more accurate, more lifelike, more naturalistic in terms of their effectiveness in representing a subject. We wish at the outset to call into question such a presumption, for two main reasons. First, any presumption of what it means to be "accurate, lifelike, naturalistic" is, itself, the result of conventions, conventions which are artificial and culturally determined. Secondly, the presumption leads, too often and too swiftly, into another presumption: that any painting which is thought to be more "accurate, lifelike, naturalistic" is necessarily better than another which is deemed to measure less on this particular gradient. This presumption is also artificial and culturally determined; a goal of this text is to encourage you to become more fully aware of how the conception of painting as a language empowers you, as both a potential creator and viewer of other artworks, to explore painting broadly and to examine all rules and traditions with an open mind.

Research and Discussion Exercise

What Is Realism?

What does it mean to paint "realistically"? There may be as many answers as there are cultures with traditions and

Focus On

PAINTINGS OF ANIMALS

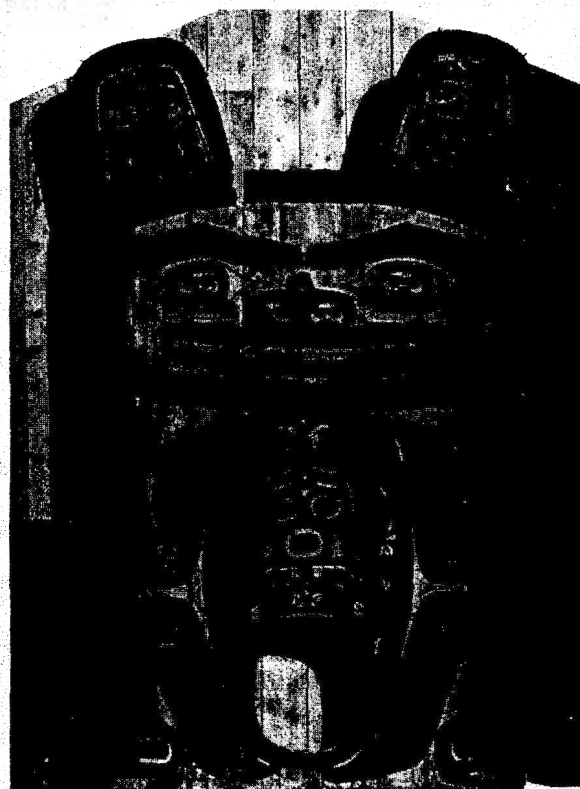
Figures 1.5, 1.6, and 1.7

Figures 1.5, 1.6, and 1.7, made by artists in very different cultures, show the use of different symbolic conventions to represent animals.

Figure 1.5, made by a Tlingit artist from the Northwest Coast of North America, is an image of a brown bear painted on a huge wooden screen. Tlingit painters frequently use animals as subject matter, and share highly conventionalized methods for rendering them, including the simplification and exaggeration of characteristic body parts, which serve as signs to identify the entire animal. Rounded upright ears and a wide head are signs for a bear, for example, as in Figure 1.5. Among other conventions of Northwest Coast art adhered to in this painting are the use of frontality and *split representation*: an approach in which the image of the animal is divided into two equal halves, and body parts are flattened and rearranged so that all parts are visible in a symmetrical design. Another convention is to fill empty spaces, such as ears, eyes, nostrils, and other body cavities with faces and in some cases complete animals. The image as a whole also functions as a sign: the brown bear is an emblem which signifies the clan of the Tlingit chief for whom this screen was made.

Bruce Nabekeyo, an Aboriginal Australian artist, made Figure 1.6, painting in earth tones on a sheet of tree bark. Known to us as bark painting, this is an ancient method (although only recent examples exist since the medium is impermanent). The artist represents the serpent in an "X-ray" image showing both its outside and inside, a characteristic convention in Aboriginal art from northern Australia. The water lilies on the serpent's back symbolize the water where she lives. The Aboriginal audience for whom this bark painting was made would have immediately recognized the image as an episode from a creation myth about the serpent Yingarna, that swallows and regurgitates humans.

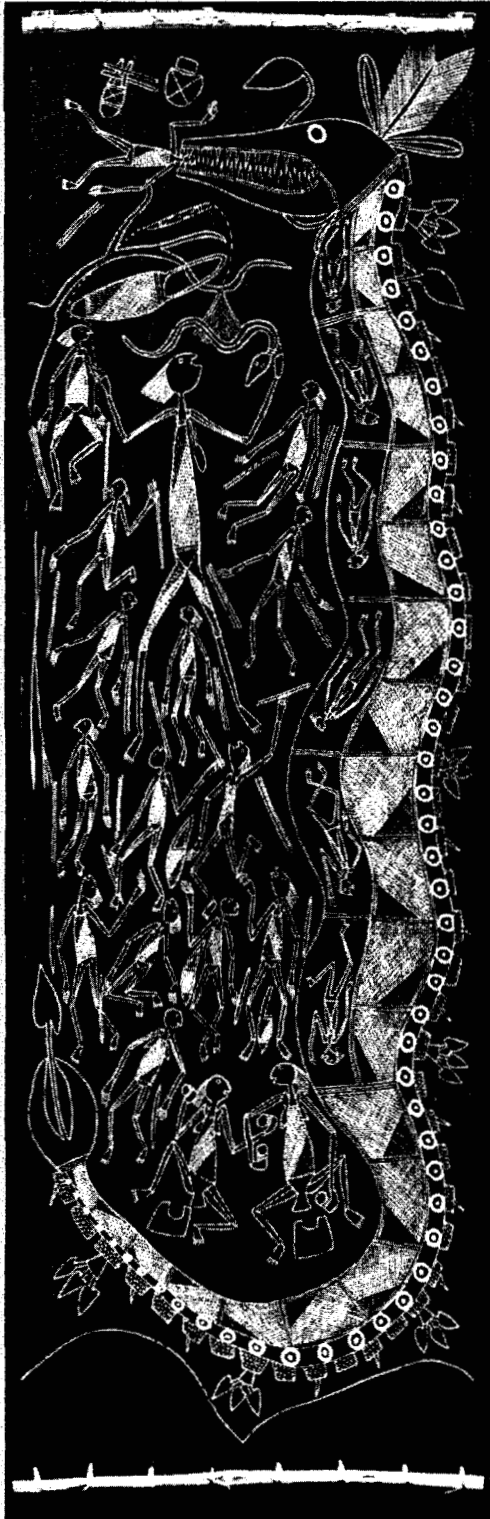
Finally, Figure 1.7 was painted by Giacomo Balla, who was a member of the movement known



1.5 Tlingit bear screen, c. 1840. Wood and paint, 15' × 9'. Native Arts, American Indian. Denver Art Museum.

as *Futurism*, launched in Italy in 1909. Futurists wanted to create a new art built on sensations of speed and dynamic movement. Balla's decision not to show the dog as a static form with a single fixed contour results in an eye-catching strategy for representing a moving subject in a painting. We easily understand the repetition of the forms of the feet, tail, and leash as signs for a person walking a dog. The convention is unusual but not arbitrary; by Balla's time, advances in stop-action photography had taught many people to understand movement as just such a closely repeated sequence.

(continued)



1.7 Giacomo Balla, *Dynamism of a Dog on a Leash*, 1912.
Oil on canvas, $35 \frac{5}{8}'' \times 43 \frac{1}{4}''$. Albright-Knox Art Gallery,
Buffalo, N.Y. Bequest of A. Conger Goodyear and Gift of
George F. Goodyear, 1964.

1.6 Bruce Nabekeyo, *The Rainbow Serpent, Yingarna*, 1989.
Natural pigments on eucalyptus bark, 150×404 cm.
National Gallery of Australia, Canberra.

conventions of painting. Each class member should bring in for discussion examples of the following:

- an ordinary photographic snapshot;
- a computer-generated illustration (from a magazine or other source);
- an illustration of a painting which you think is "life-like";
- an illustration of a painting from a culture you have never researched before.

Discuss what you mean by "realism," attempting to find ways that each image you have brought in for discussion can be said to represent (at least partially) an aspect of visual or physical reality. In other words, strive for a more rather than less expansive understanding of visual realism.

KEEPING A STUDIO JOURNAL

This book uses informal writing as a tool to help you, a student of painting, unlock your creativity, understand the meaning of art you have already made, gauge the effectiveness of paintings you are working on, and explore new avenues for future images. The book is based on the premise that expressing yourself in a personal voice in writing will help you to discover your personal voice in painting; formulating into words your reaction to a painting (in progress or completed) will foster an increased awareness of how a painting functions as a complex, visual form of communication. While painting is anchored in the visual, its analysis for the artist and the viewer operates in both the visual and verbal realms. Articulating your thoughts about painting in words should be an invaluable and integral process in learning to paint.

Keeping a studio journal, in fact, has been an important practice for many artists. Such notable painters as Leonardo da Vinci and Max Beckmann (Figure 5.1) used journal writing as a way of working out their ideas, making sketches, recording information, and analyzing their progress on specific projects. Moreover, many painters have published their thoughts on studio techniques, artistic purposes, the creative process, and philosophical content in books and essays.

Using Writing to Explore Content

When and why should you, as a student of painting, use the process of writing?

- **SOMETIMES:** Early in the painting process, or even before you have started a painting, we recommend undertaking an occasional writing exercise to help you discover new, different, or deeper ideas for a painting. Journal writing can help unlock your creativity by pointing the way to topics and ideas of strong, personal interest, perhaps recovering memories of events and subjects that once held strong emotional attachments for you.
- **OFTEN:** During the late stages of the painting process, an informal, written analysis of your painting-in-progress can be an invaluable aid to discovering what you *now* think your painting means, and how effective you judge each part and the whole are in embodying and communicating this meaningfulness.
- **ALWAYS:** Write at the end of the painting process, when you are preparing to discuss and share your ideas about your painting's development and meaning to others, for example, in advance of a group critique. Articulating your thoughts into writing will make your own thinking clearer and will help you become more effective in articulating your thoughts to others. Gauging what we, as artists, think a painting means to us, and comparing its effect on others, is an invaluable step in developing our artistic vocabulary and skills.

Guidelines for Journal Writing

Supplies

The only supplies you need for the writing exercises in this book are a pen or pencil, paper, and a folder or notebook to collect your responses. Or you may choose to write on a computer (perhaps keeping all entries together under one file labeled "painting journal"). It is a good idea to keep all the responses in one place so you can refer back to them easily.

When and Where to Write

You should respond to journal exercises as soon as possible after they are assigned, and certainly before a class where responses will be discussed by the group. You will find that writing goes more smoothly when you do it frequently, just as a physical activity becomes easier as you practice it. You will reach deeper insights because today's writing will build on that of yesterday and the day before.

Your teacher may direct you to undertake a writing exercise during class time. Outside class, you should set aside at least twenty minutes when you won't be interrupted for each journal exercise. That is the minimum amount of time you need to let a train of thought run

freely as you write. Some exercises require more than twenty minutes.

When and where you write is not important as long as you can be alone with your thoughts. Experiment with different times and places to write, and discover what works best for you.

Who Will Read the Journal?

Your teacher may want to collect your journal from time to time to assess your development. Otherwise, you are the primary audience for your writing. While some of your writing will serve to clarify your own thinking before engaging in a group discussion, most often you are writing to inform yourself about the development of an individual artwork and to explore who you are as an artist and what experiences, ideas, feelings, and perceptions you want to express in your art. You should record insights about yourself openly and honestly.

If you are using this book for a classroom text, you may be discussing responses to the exercises as a group. You will quickly learn that many people want to share their writing. But no one should feel pressured to share private material who doesn't wish to. You may discuss your general reactions to an exercise in class if you don't want to talk about specific details of what you wrote. Hearing many painters' responses to the same journal exercise is an invaluable experience. You see your own perspective more vividly when it is put up against a broad curtain of other viewpoints. You may expand or change your perspective under the impact of different ways of thinking about an issue. Moreover, you gain a more complex awareness of diversity, which promotes tolerance.

How to Write

The journal exercises do not require you to use the formal language you would need for an academic research paper. Instead, use your personal voice, language that comes naturally to you. Don't struggle to sound witty or brilliant. Just write your thoughts in the same way you might say them aloud to a trusted friend. Using a natural voice in writing can be a means of finding your personal vision in painting.

Take risks and write freely. The exercises should be taken as suggestions for self-reflection and catalysts to inspire your painting, not as ironclad directives. Many exercises are in parts, and you may find that you only want to respond to one of the parts. You may also choose to complete longer exercises in stages, over more than one session of writing.

Deviate from the exercises whenever you wish. Follow a renegade train of thought if it calls you forward. A

branching path might prove to be the right direction for you.

Think of your responses as opportunities to think out loud on paper, not as finished, polished documents. If you decide later that you want to use sections of your writing for an artist's statement or other public communication, you can always go back to revise and edit.

You should date each piece of writing and give it a brief title — probably the same title as the exercise — to help you sort through your writing later.

Directed Freewriting

When you freewrite you write for a specified period of time without stopping. Usually you begin with the first thought that pops into your mind and start to write spontaneously without worrying about what will come next, using a stream-of-consciousness technique. If you want a variation, begin with a certain question or idea, then write freely in response to that catalyst. The latter kind of *directed freewriting* is the approach we suggest in most exercises in this book.

For directed freewriting, read the exercise carefully, then spend at least twenty minutes writing down continuously every thought that comes into your mind in response to the issues and questions raised in the exercise. You do not have to write rapidly but you should write steadily without stopping and without going back to reread what you have written so far. Write phrases and words if complete sentences don't come to mind. When the twenty minutes are up, you may reread what you have written. Then, if you wish, add any other thoughts that occur to you.

Relaxation

Try to put yourself in a meditative state of mind before you begin to write. Turn off the television and radio. Sit in a comfortable chair. Stare at an object in front of you and empty your mind of distracting outside thoughts. Relax every part of your body. Close your eyes and slowly breathe in to a count of eight, then slowly exhale. When you feel ready, open your eyes. Pick up your pen and begin!

VISITING MUSEUMS AND LIBRARIES

We strongly advocate that you look at as many paintings as possible while you are learning to paint, from all

places and periods. At first the variety may seem overwhelming, but gradually you will become familiar with the conventions employed by certain cultures and individual artists and will be able to discern the subtle qualities that distinguish the most compelling paintings made by a particular culture or artist. Take from these paintings what you can: try out techniques, materials, compositional schemes, formal devices, subject matter, and cognitive ideas that intrigue you in the paintings of other artists. Learning by imitation is a time-honored practice and, indeed, in numerous societies recreating traditional styles and approaches has been considered the proper goal for mature artists.

The best way to see art is to see it firsthand, in museums, galleries, and other public collections, artists' studios, and private collections, if you are lucky enough to know someone who owns a lot of art. *There is no substitute for the real thing.* Reproductions of paintings in books, magazines, on the Internet, and elsewhere are convenient, but they give an incomplete and distorted view. An obvious distortion is *scale* (the size of a painting). With rare exceptions, the scale of a reproduction in a book is never the same as the actual painting, and the reproduction can be extremely misleading. Did you realize, for instance, that Bonheur's painting of horses is over 16 feet wide (Figure 1.3), eight times the size of the painting by McCarthy to which we compared it (Figure 1.4)? The grandeur of Bonheur's horses is unforgettable for a viewer in front of the actual painting. Reproductions of paintings also misrepresent surface textures by reducing variations in brushstrokes; with black-and-white illustrations, important color relationships are eliminated.

We urge you to visit local museums and art collections in your community, and visit them often. Great paintings are inexhaustible; there is always something else to be learned by seeing them again. Travel to cities in your region to see some of the great collections of paintings available to the public. Start saving your money and planning a trip to another country: the visual and intellectual charge of visiting a different culture is invaluable for an artist.

With all this said, we realize that if you were only to look at paintings in person, you would never know about most of the work that has been produced in history and the new paintings being created today. Thus we highly recommend looking at reproductions of paintings in any and all sources, as long as you keep in mind that you are seeing substitutes for actual paintings. There are many high quality art books in print. Increasingly the Internet gives you access to electronic simulations of museum exhibitions and collections. The more you see, the more

you will get ideas for your own paintings. Remember, a picture is worth a thousand words: open your eyes and look at what paintings have to teach you!

USING DRAWING TO PREPARE FOR PAINTING

In addition to undertaking the writing exercises outlined in this book, your approach to painting should be augmented by the regular use of a sketchbook. Using a sketchbook provides you with a convenient means of developing and recording visual ideas — possibly even ones that occur to you while doing one of the writing exercises or looking at paintings in museums or artworks reproduced in books. Some artists utilize the same studio journal for recording written thoughts and visual sketches. For larger sketches you can utilize additional sheets.

We strongly encourage the use of drawing as a way to try alternative approaches to a composition prior to starting the actual painting. If you have had previous training in drawing this should help you develop painting skills, because many of the same principles of composition apply to both. Moreover, while drawings are often finished artworks in themselves, artists also use drawings to plan paintings. For example, a study in black, white, and shades of gray may be done in order to plan the value relationships of a painting to be completed in full color.

Richard Diebenkorn's pencil and ink wash sketch, entitled *Seated Woman with a Hat* (Figure 1.8), is just such a study. Diebenkorn preferred to use drawing as a way to respond directly to the living model; typically his compositions for paintings were developed later in the studio.³ Compare the drawing with Diebenkorn's oil painting, *Seated Figure with Hat* (Plate 1). While the positions of some body parts have been altered in the painting, many *value* relationships (relationships of darkness and lightness) remain the same. In both, the heightened contrast between light flesh tones on the near arm and the darker top of the figure's clothing help bring that arm closer. The shadowed face, in reduced contrast to the background, recedes in space. We examine Diebenkorn's use of color in this painting in the next chapter.

Tips for Using a Sketchbook

Draw a margin on all four sides of each sketchbook page prior to using it. Most artists are inhibited from drawing



1.8 Richard Diebenkorn, *Seated Woman with a Hat*, 1967. Pencil and ink wash, 14" × 17". Private collection.

right to or intersecting the edge of a page, and without a margin your compositions will not utilize the full space. Drawn margins will encourage you to consider the entire picture plane as you develop a composition, allowing you to work to the edges and into the corners.

Sketch often!

DEVELOPING HAND AND EYE SKILLS

We do not advocate any attempt to confine painting to one tradition or "canon." Nevertheless we support the

need for beginning painters to develop certain skills and certain knowledge: particularly hand skills at mixing and applying paint; perceptual skills at observing visual reality and translating perceptions into paint; conceptual knowledge of fundamental terms and strategies; and intuitive, nonverbal knowledge (what some writers call tacit knowledge) as you learn by doing how *your* paintings are made.

Many exercises in the early chapters of the text stress learning to paint in a representational mode (again, paintings which represent subject matter in an identifiable way). Learning to paint a subject so that it is identifiable challenges the beginning painter to coordinate the processes of looking, seeing, and mark making. No matter which style (or styles) of painting you may ultimately

develop, learning to respond to the visual qualities of a subject in front of you should enhance your development. Moreover, many historic cultures around the world developed varieties of realistic representation, and representational visual art remains a strong current within the practice of contemporary painting.

Research in Visual Perception

Research in the process of human vision has established that what we think we see often differs in significant ways from the image that actually falls on the retina. While even a modest summary of recent experimentation and theorization in human vision is beyond the scope of this text, we believe it is valuable for you, the developing painter, to recognize that you cannot rely strictly on painting things as you *think* you see them and expect to achieve an accurate naturalistic representation.⁴ The human mind operates automatically in ways that often value identification more than perception. While we look with our eyes, we see with our mind. Perception and conception are intricately linked together in the process of human vision. Two examples: experimental evidence suggests that humans are prone to what psychologists call “size constancy” and “shape constancy.” Our minds tend to make corrections so that in looking at distant identifiable things we “see” them as if they were closer to their known size, and in looking at identifiable shapes we “see” them corrected so that they aren’t turned away from us at odd or acute angles. Such mental corrections are quite effective in helping us to identify the things we are looking at, but they also serve to thwart the artist who wishes to paint with perceptual accuracy.

Artists have developed strategies to overcome the conceptual nature of human vision. If the goal is to paint what your retina sees and not what your mind knows (i.e., your retina perceives an elongated parallelogram, but your mind knows the table has a rectangular top) one useful strategy is to concentrate on painting the *negative shapes* (the shapes formed by background areas lying between the outlines of painted objects and figures). Because you don’t know the negative shapes conceptually, you will not be as prone to distortion of size or shape. Look at and paint the shape of the air under and over the table, rather than painting the table itself.

A WORD ABOUT THE CREATIVE PROCESS

This text emphasizes the planned exploration of a variety of painting techniques, approaches to the use of materials, strategies for the articulation of form, and exercises to enhance the development of cognitive meaning. A painter who possesses only limited and disorganized knowledge is in danger of being stuck in a rut he or she cannot see a way out of; knowledge empowers the painter to explore new directions for creating expressive meaning. By arming the developing painter with knowledge of fundamental approaches and concepts from a rich range of traditions, we ensure that the painter’s efforts will, ultimately, be less likely to become formulaic. Equally important, while we believe that a developing artist can gain important conceptual insights and invaluable practical experiences while learning fundamental strategies in a systematic way, we hope that this textbook and its suggestions will also serve as springboards for one’s own further unplanned and intuitive experimentation.

Experiment, explore, be creative!

1. In addition to effecting a visual experience, a painting also effects a tactile experience. The painter responds to the tangible qualities of paint as he or she works, and a viewer indirectly senses the textural qualities, whether the painting has a smooth, glossy finish or is a buildup of thick, peaked brushstrokes. In response to the malleability of painting’s formal language, some artists and writers refer to the formal elements as plastic elements.
2. In Chapter 8 we look more specifically at the conception of painting as a language from a semiotic point of view. (Briefly put, semiotics is the study of signs, and a sign is, basically, something which stands for something else.)
3. Gerald Nordland, *Richard Diebenkorn* (New York: Rizzoli, 1987), p. 114.
4. Excellent discussions of some of the more important research efforts and theoretical developments focusing on perception and the interpretation of visual images can be found in Howard S. Hoffman, *Vision and the Art of Drawing* (Englewood Cliffs, NJ: Prentice-Hall, 1989) and Paul Messaris, *Visual Literacy: Image, Mind, and Reality* (Boulder, CO: Westview Press, 1994).